

she and her parents started working with the talent manager Dan Dymtrow. With his help, Swift modeled for Abercrombie & Fitch, had an original song included on a Maybelline compilation CD, and was given an artist development deal from RCA Records at 13.^{[25][26]} To help Swift break into the country music scene, her father transferred to Merrill Lynch's Nashville office when she was 14 years old, and the family relocated to Hendersonville, Tennessee.^{[27][28]} Swift attended Hendersonville High School for two years before transferring to Aaron Academy, which offered homeschooling.^{[3][29][30]}

2004–2008: Career beginnings and *Taylor Swift*



Swift promoting her debut album in 2007

Swift signed with Sony/ATV Tree Music Publishing in 2004; at 14, she became the youngest person in that publishing company's history.^[31] In Nashville, she worked with experienced Music Row songwriters, including Liz Rose.^{[32][33]} Rose and Swift would write songs every Tuesday afternoon after school.^[34] After one year on the development deal, she left RCA Records, which was planning to keep her in development until she turned 18.^[35] Swift made this decision because she wanted to release the songs immediately to ensure that they still resonated with her teenage experiences.^[36]

Swift organized a showcase concert at the Bluebird Cafe on November 3, 2004; among the attendees was Scott Borchetta, a music executive who was planning to establish an independent record label called Big Machine Records.^[37] She signed a recording contract with Big Machine two weeks after the concert, on the condition that her albums would be self-written;^{[38][39]} her father purchased a three-percent stake in the company.^[40] The contract was finalized by July 2005, when Swift ended her working relationship with Dymtrow.^[41] She spent four months near the end of 2005 recording her debut album, *Taylor Swift*, with the producer Nathan Chapman.^[42]

Swift's debut single, "Tim McGraw", was released in June 2006. She and her mother spent mid-2006 sending promotional copies of the song to country radio stations across the US.^[43] *Taylor Swift* was released on October 24, 2006.^[44] On the US Billboard 200 chart, the album peaked at number five and spent 157 weeks on the chart—the longest chart run by an album in the 2000s.^[45] With *Taylor Swift*, she became the first female country music artist to write or co-write every track on a platinum-certified debut album.^[46] Swift promoted the album with a six-month radio tour and by opening for other country artists, including Rascal Flatts in 2006,^{[42][47]} and George Strait,^[48] Brad Paisley,^[49] and Tim McGraw and Faith Hill in 2007.^[50] She opened for Rascal Flatts again in 2008,^[51] when she dated the singer Joe Jonas.^[52]

Taylor Swift was supported by four more singles in 2007 and 2008: "Teardrops on My Guitar", "Our Song", "Picture to Burn", and "Should've Said No". "Our Song" and "Should've Said No" reached number one on the Hot Country Songs chart; with the former single, Swift became the youngest person to single-handedly write and sing a number-one country single.^[53] "Teardrops on My Guitar" was Swift's breakthrough single on mainstream radio and charts, reaching the top 10 of the Pop Songs, Adult Pop Songs, and Adult Contemporary charts.^{[54][55]} Her next releases were the Christmas